

At Dr. House's recommendation, I then ended up hooking up with Dr. Robert Slavin of Johns Hopkins, who was probably the number one education researcher in the country at the time, and he had put together a program in reading and math for kindergarten and first grade students. I looked at the statistics for the program, and while it did achieve significant results, only about 50 percent to 60 percent of the students were at grade level. The program is called *Success for All*. I asked Dr. Slavin, "How could you truly get success for all? Would more money help?" He said, "Of course, if it is spent in the right way."

I went back to the same school in which I had backed the seventh-grade class and told the superintendent, "Give me an elementary school, and I will spend money until all the kids can read." He turned me down. After some other failed efforts, I finally found a school in Queens that was interested, and we started the program there for K to 5. In the second year of the program, they won an award for being one of the most improved schools in the state.

How much were you spending per child?

\$1,000/year per child.

That's all! What was the essence of the program?

We provided tutoring in math and English, using tutors that were trained in the Success for All program. We also had professionals who monitored the kids so that anyone who needed help would get it. We couldn't hire the tutors through the public school system because of all the red tape. So I just ended up providing them for free. Because I had so much trouble navigating through the bureaucracy of the public school system, I met with Joel Klein.⁶ He suggested that I should consider opening a charter school, which would give us the flexibility to hire our own teachers.

In 2006, John Petry and I started a single charter school based on the business model that it would serve as a prototype that could be expanded to other schools if it were successful. We designed the program from the beginning so that it could be replicated. We hired Eva Moskowitz, who is amazing, to run the program. Eva has now opened nine charter schools, with four more scheduled to start next year.